

What is SAML?

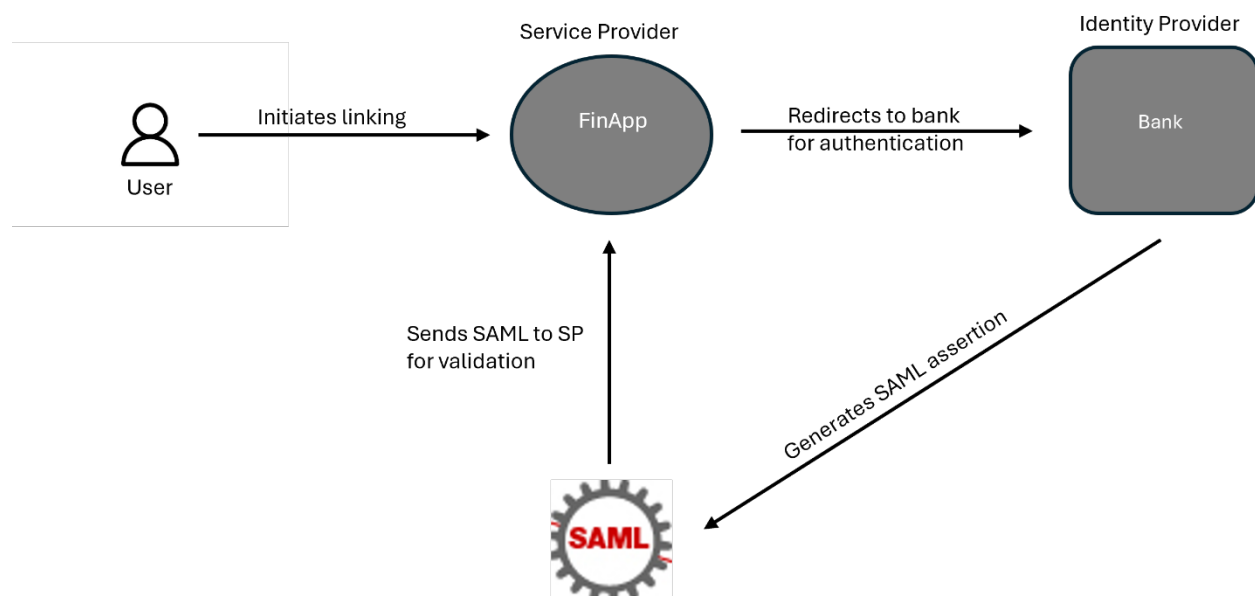
Security Assertion Markup Language (SAML) is an XML-based protocol for exchanging security information between software entities on the Web. SAML provides single sign-on (SSO) capabilities. Users can authenticate at one location and access service providers at other locations without logging in multiple times.

How SAML Works

SAML exchanges user information, such as logins and other relevant attributes, between the identity provider (IdP) and the service provider (SP). It secures and simplifies the authentication process because the user only needs to log in once with one set of authentication credentials. When the user accesses a site, the identity provider passes the SAML authentication to the service provider, who then grants the user entry.

In the following example, a user wants to use a third-party financial application (FinApp) to manage their bank accounts from different banks.

1. The user logs into their FinApp account.
2. The user chooses to link a bank account within FinApp.
3. FinApp (SP) redirects the user to the selected bank's login page (IdP).
4. The user enters their credentials (username and password) on the bank's login page.
5. Upon successful authentication, the bank generates a SAML assertion containing information about the user and their authentication status.
6. The bank sends the SAML assertion to FinApp through the user's browser.
7. FinanceApp validates the SAML assertion to ensure it's legitimate and has not been tampered with.
8. Once validated, FinApp links the bank account to the user's FinApp account.
9. The user repeats the process to link additional bank accounts. Each time, SML redirects to the respective bank's IdP for authentication, and a new SAML assertion is generated and validated by FinApp.



FinApp ensures that the authentication process is secure and that each respective bank verifies the user's identity by using SAML assertions for each bank. This process allows the user to link multiple bank accounts to their FinanceApp account securely and seamlessly.

What are the Benefits of SAML

SAML improves the user experience by requiring only one sign-in to access multiple web applications and speeds up the authentication process. It also provides increased security because the identity provider stores all of the login information, not the service provider.